

but instead of concentrating all his troops there, he sent 12,000 men to reinforce Fort Donelson. Command of the fort was placed in the hands of John Floyd, a controversial secretary of war in the Buchanan government before the war.

First attacks on Fort Donelson

General Halleck's intention after the fall of Fort Henry was to hold what had been gained. Grant had finally arrived at Fort Henry on February 14 after a difficult march, but set off for Fort Donelson as soon as he could. There he was reinforced by a further 10,000 troops sent by Halleck, giving him clear numerical superiority over the fort's defenders—25,000 Union soldiers faced 16,000 Confederates. The Confederate strongpoint was not a fort in the conventional sense. It was a 15-acre (6-hectare) encampment defended on the river side by batteries of heavy guns dug into the high cliffs and on the landward side by field fortifications that exploited the rugged terrain of wooded slopes and ravines.

The first attempt on the fort was made by Foote's flotilla, but the fire from the high-placed shore batteries, directed downward to crash through the ships' decks, disabled the Union vessels one by one. There followed an attack on the landward side of the fort, led by one of Grant's divisional commanders, John McClelland, but this was also repulsed. Grant faced the uncomfortable prospect of a long siege in harsh winter weather. His men settled down opposite the Confederate trenches in conditions of considerable hardship, some without overcoats or blankets, sleeping on the bare ground in freezing rain and snow.